

THE DISRUPTOR
Manoj Jarange-Patil with his supporters at Navi Mumbai, Oct. 2023

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MAHARASHTRA

A STORM CALLED JARANGE-PATIL

By Dhaval Kulkarni

The political arena in Maharashtra is witnessing a seismic shift, triggered by a catalyst called Manoj Jarange-Patil. The relatively obscure activist shot into the limelight in September 2023, during a lathicharge incident in Jalna district, where he was staging a fast unto death while advocating quotas for his community—the Marathas.

After two impactful fasts last year that compelled the Eknath Shinde-led coalition government to take note and seek more time, Jarange-Patil launched a fresh round of protests as 2024 dawned, embarking on a march from Jalna to Mumbai on January 20. Joined by thousands on the way, it was meant to culminate at Azad Maidan where Jarange-Patil was to launch a fast seeking the Marathas' inclusion in the Other Backward Class (OBC) category by giving them Kunbi caste certificates and make them eligible for quotas in education, jobs and politics.

Faced with the threat of hundreds of thousands of protesters converging on India's financial capital, the state government relented. On January 27, it issued a controversial draft notification making it simpler for the Marathas to get certificates as Kunbis—that is, a form of reverse mobility for those seen to have ascended to warrior status, back to the tiller or peasant class they emerged from historically, with whom they still share ties as the '*sage soyare*' or relatives from the same family tree. Shinde, the face of the government's response, went down to Vashi and got Jarange-Patil to call off his agitation. On January 30, Jarange-Patil threatened to launch a fast from February 10 if the government didn't act on its commitments.

THE FALLOUT

- **Jarange-Patil's agitation has disrupted the established political order, intensified caste identities and complicated electoral strategies**
- **Relenting, the Maha government has issued a draft notification making it easier for Marathas to get Kunbi caste certificates**

Veteran Maratha leaders note that Jarange-Patil had evoked the sympathy of the rural, agrarian Marathas, especially those from the dust bowl of Marathwada, where he hails from. They attribute it to reasons like agrarian distress, unaffordable education, competition for government jobs, the inability of men to find brides and a growing competition with the upwardly mobile and increasingly assertive OBCs. On the other hand, the Maratha quota demand has sparked resentment among the OBCs, who fear the potential loss of benefits. This discord manifested in violent incidents targeting OBC leaders and their properties in Beed district.

Despite the fractured state of Maharashtra politics, with the Shiv Sena and Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) experiencing successive splits, there is consensus over one catalysing factor: the role of Jarange-Patil as disruptor. His agitation has not only intensified caste identities but also complicated the electoral calculus, making cross-group support a challenging proposition.

While Jarange-Patil disavows political aspirations, his agitation is setting off repercussions across the state. A member of a prominent political family notes that Jarange-Patil's protest—combined with the splits in the Sena and NCP—will see several inimical forces collaborate, collide and work at cross-purposes in the forthcoming Lok Sabha and the assembly polls due by October.

The counter-mobilisation led by OBC leader and NCP minister Chhagan Bhujbal may create a larger sense of OBC solidarity and shake the traditional Maratha dominance over Maharashtra's polity by isolating them to an extent. Bhujbal vows to mount a legal challenge against what he deems a "backdoor entry" for the Marathas.

Born into poverty in Beed district's Matori in Shirur-Kasar taluka,